

HSL748-Guidelines

May 6, 2026

Guidelines

The "Primary Technique" Test Ask yourself, "What is the specific trick that makes this joke funny?" If you remove or alter that specific element, does the joke completely lose its punchline? The element that bears the load of the humor is the primary technique.

1. Read the entire setup and punchline without over-analyzing. Identify where the "laugh" or the "pivot" happens. 2. Isolate the Technique: Determine exactly how the author subverted your expectations.

Category Definitions

1. Surprise

Definition: The humor relies on a "mental recalibration moment." The setup leads down a specific logical path, and the punchline abruptly forces you to reframe the entire context in an unexpected direction (violating expectations). "I didn't see that coming." kind of setup.

What to look for: A clear setup that builds an assumption, followed by a punchline that completely changes the context of the setup.

Example: My neighbor knocked on my door this morning at 2:30 AM! ----- Luckily for him I was still up playing my drums.

2. Irony

Definition: The humor arises from a gap between surface meaning and true meaning (verbal irony/sarcasm), or a sharp contrast between what is expected to happen and what actually happens (situational irony). It states the contrary of what is meant or presents a contradiction between expression and context.

What to look for: Sarcasm, hypocrisy, or a scenario where an object/person fails in a way that directly contradicts its core purpose.

Example: Legend has it that Charlie Chaplin once entered a "Charlie Chaplin walk" contest—and came in 20th.

3. Wordplay

Definition: The humor is derived from the manipulation at the phonological (sound) or morphological (structure) level of words. This includes puns, words with multiple meanings, and taking the literal meaning of an idiom or metaphor.

What to look for: Homophones, double entendres, or phrases that can be interpreted two entirely different ways.

Example: "Whenever I'm at the therapist's waiting room, I stand in one corner and blow air at people.....Everyone hates it, but I'm a fan."

4. Absurdity

Definition: The humor comes from defying the rules of reality, logic, or proportion. It relies on hyperbole, surrealism, or completely nonsensical scenarios being treated as normal, implying a breakdown in meaning on a logical or existential level.

What to look for: Situations that are physically impossible in the real world, cartoonish overreactions, or purely surreal setups.

Example: My doctor says I'm not eating a balanced diet...that's wrong. I eat as many cookies with my left hand as I do with my right!

Why did the bed cross the road? Because he wanted to send e-mail from space and there were no telephone poles.

Miscellaneous

Definition: The joke does not fit neatly into the above categories.

Humorous vs Non-Humorous

If you feel a joke is funny enough to elicit a laugh, mark it as humorous, and if it is not funny enough, mark it as non-humorous.

Overlap Resolution (Why This, Not That)

When a joke appears to fit into multiple categories, use these tests to determine the Primary Technique.

Wordplay vs. Surprise

It is common for wordplay to feel surprising because the sudden double meaning catches the reader off guard. However, the distinction lies in the foundation of the joke.

The Word vs. Concept Test: Ask yourself where the pivot actually happens. Is the trick embedded in the vocabulary, or in the narrative?

If the humor relies on a linguistic trick at the word level (e.g., a pun, homophone, or dual definition), the primary technique is Wordplay. If the humor relies on a sudden shift at the conceptual level—where the situation, assumption, or narrative entirely changes—the primary technique is Surprise. For example in the joke; "Why are polar bears so good in conversations? Because they live on broken ice." is wordplay as it relies on the literalization of an idiom but a joke such as "How do you stop a fight between two blind men? Just say you're rooting for the man with the knife." is a surprise as the pivot happens at the narrative level.

Irony vs. Surprise

Surprise is when the punchline reveals a scenario that is completely different from what you assumed. It relies on a shift in perspective or missing information. Irony is when the punchline reveals an outcome that is the opposite of what is logically intended or expected. It relies on a contradiction of purpose. The Test: Does the punchline represent the exact opposite of what was stated or intended, or is it just different from what you expected?

In the example, "My neighbor knocked on my door this morning at 2:30 AM! Luckily for him I was still up playing my drums." The punchline reveals that the narrator is the villain of the story, and the neighbor wants quiet leading to re-evaluation of the scene.

Whereas in the example, "Legend has it that Charlie Chaplin once entered a 'Charlie Chaplin walk' contest—and came in 20th." It is irony and not surprise, as it involves contradiction as the scenario plays out in the exact opposite way it is supposed to.

Absurdity vs. Surprise

In surprise, punchline is unexpected, but once revealed, it makes logical sense within the real world. You have a recalibration moment where the pieces suddenly fit together in a new way.

In absurdity, the punchline does not make logical sense, even after the reveal. The humor comes from the fact that the meaning have broken down, yet the characters treat it as normal.

The Test: Does the punchline make literal sense in the physical universe once the trick is revealed?

In the joke, "I asked my daughter to hand me the newspaper. She told me that newspapers are old school. She said that people use tablets nowadays and handed me her iPad. The fly didn't stand a chance." smashing a fly with an iPad is a terrible idea, but it obeys the laws of physics. It is a logical twist, so it is Surprise. If the joke was "I asked my daughter for a newspaper, and she handed me a dragon that grants wishes," there is no logic. That is Absurdity.

Irony vs. Absurdity

Irony relies on the real world functioning exactly as it should, but exposing a contradiction in purpose, expectation, or meaning.

Absurdity relies on the breakdown of logic, or meaning. It treats a completely nonsensical scenario as if it were normal.

The Test: Does the joke highlight a contradiction within the real world, or does it break the rules of the real world entirely?

In the joke, "My doctor says I'm not eating a balanced diet...that's wrong. I eat as many cookies with my left hand as I do with my right!". The logic of equating "balanced nutrition" to "physical symmetry of the hands" represents a breakdown of logical reasoning. It is a nonsensical argument treated as normal.

Whereas, in the joke "Legend has it that Charlie Chaplin once entered a 'Charlie Chaplin walk' contest—and came in 20th." This scenario obeys the laws of physics however, it presents a contradiction. The actual Charlie Chaplin failing at being Charlie Chaplin directly contradicts the core purpose of the contest.

Labels to be Used

- Surprise- S

- Irony- I
- Wordplay- W
- Absurdity- A
- Miscellaneous- M
- Humorous- 1
- Non-humorous- 0